CURSE OF STRAHD: DEATH HOUSE (MIDNIGHT ROSE)

D&D 5.5E

BEST SILVER SELLER



EXCALIBUR PENN

Escape from Death House by midnight in this revamped adventure for the world's greatest roleplaying game!

GUILD

CURSE OF STRAHD: DEATH HOUSE (MIDNIGHT ROSE)

A Curse of Strahd D&D 5.5E Adventure
Optimized For: Average Party Level (APL) 2
A Four- to Six-Hour Adventure for Tier 1 Characters

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Content Warning: This product contains elements of body, dark fantasy, folk, gothic, occult, psychological, and slasher horror.



Boxed Text

At various places, the adventure presents narrative text that is meant to be read to the players by the Dungeon Master, as the narrator of this story. This descriptive text is offset in boxes like this one. Boxed text is most used to give a picture of rooms or present portions of scripted dialogue necessary for storytelling.

PLAYING THE PILLARS

Combat. There are multiple combat scenarios, especially in the dungeon level. Gauge the party's combat strength continuously. Combat is designed to be challenging without being hopelessly crushing, **if** good tactics and role-play techniques are used. Sometimes the **best** answer in a horror setting is to flee and escape. The adventure includes suggestions and options for average, weaker, and stronger parties based upon their Average Party Level (APL).

Exploration. The adventure is filled with spooky haunts, bizarre clues, and phobias for your players to investigate. The House is able to summon previous versions of rooms and creatures, causing a perplexing mix for your sleuths. Tracking time during the exploration of the House will have a significant impact on the final results of the adventure.

Social. The characters will have the opportunity to make allies or foes depending on their alignment, goals, and role-play style. Potential ghostly allies await and the rescue of a story-nexus NPC add role-playing and future story options.

HORROR: PLAYING IT SAFE

Horror Limits. Be sure to fully understand your personal horror limits before purchasing or playing this adventure. You will also need to be familiar with your players' limits.

Social Contract. Be sure to establish a social contract with your players during Session Zero. Check in with the players as the adventure unfolds; they may find new limits.

Safety Tools. In addition, have a simple safety tool that allows your players to pause, slow down, or stop the game session whenever in-game events lead to real-world stress. Choose a tool that you all agree upon.

LEVEL ADVANCEMENT

Milestone Goals. In this adventure, the characters will gain levels only by completing specific milestone goals, rather than by defeating monsters or acquiring treasure:

- The characters must gain access to the dungeon level through Area 21 to advance one level.
- The characters will advance an additional one level when they successfully survive, escape, *and* rescue Ireena out of the House (The Great Escape).

Introduction

Welcome to *Curse of Strahd: Death House (Midnight Rose)*, a Dungeons & Dragons (D&D) 5.5e mini-adventure module. This horror adventure is intended for 4-6 characters of first to third level with an Average Party Level (APL) of 2.

The Core Rulebooks (*Player's Handbook*, *Monster Manual*, and *Dungeon Master's Guide*) and the *Curse of Strahd* (CoS) Sourcebook are required to run this adventure. As always, while not required, *Van Richten's Guide to Ravenloft* (VRGtR) is a strongly recommended horror resource. Death House has been changed in several areas from the original adventure. It is assumed that the DM is familiar with D&D abbreviations, the original adventure, and the Death House maps found in the *Curse of Strahd*, *Appendix B*.

Adventure Overview

Into the Mists. The adventure begins with our heroic characters (either as a party or individuals) who are brought together by the Mists of Ravenloft to a clearing in the Svalich Woods near the base of the Pillarstone of Ravenloft. There they will hear the scream of Rose within Death House. She has summoned the characters to help her rescue a lost young woman (Ireena) who she believes has been captured by the "monster in the basement."

Within Death House. The adventurers enter Death House. It is involved in a supernatural battle with Rose that the characters must survive in order to rescue Ireena. They only have a limited amount of time, until midnight, before the House collapses.

The Great Escape is the adventure's concluding scenario to escape Death House with Ireena before midnight. If the characters fail to escape, they will be trapped within Death House forever.

Adventure Time Budget

Depending on your time constraints, play style, and environment, this adventure may require:

- ***Into the Mists:*** 15-30 minutes.
- ***Within Death House:*** 3-5 hours.
- ***The Great Escape:*** 30-45 minutes.

Total estimated game time: 4-6 hours.

This is a timed adventure with a deadline, so you will have to keep close track of the party's time. This may be done through game time or real time, at your discretion.

Here are some things to consider:

1. Have all of your character sheets, charts, stat blocks, miniatures, VTT, music, etc., ready before you begin. Create a checklist if you must.
2. Establish a set time table for your group to hit certain milestones and finish in X hours. If using real time, consider the breaks you will take as well.
3. Give the players enough clues to recognize that the gist of this adventure is a rescue and escape.
4. Do not allow the party to get too distracted with exploring if they are running out of time. (Rose may have to remind them through supernatural means.)
5. When your time table for the final encounter and escape draws near, consider where your group is within the House. Are they anywhere close?
6. Have options ready to speed up or slow the party down based upon your timeline.

Ancient and Recent History

"Death House" is the name given to an old manor townhouse by the locals of the village of Barovia. The House itself is a cursed, sentient entity that appears either within the **Village of Barovia** (Area E7) or a small lot of cleared land just off the **Old Svalich Road** (Area A) beyond the **Gates of Barovia** (Area B) but still within the **Svalich Woods** (Area C). At times it has shown up as a dilapidated abandoned house in the middle of a graveyard. Other times as a farmhouse or cliffside manor or beside a stream.

Death House has been destroyed many times over the centuries and the locals speak of it with dark fear. If destroyed, the House can reform elsewhere at a different location with a different look or rooms within. The House in its current state has summoned hauntings, undead, and fiendish foes from its past (Durst **Cult of Strahd**, Dobromir renovation, etc.) to fulfill its goal to trap souls within.

The current rebirth of **Death House** is as an unowned, dilapidated, abandoned house at the edge of the **Svalich Woods** near the **Pillarstone of Ravenloft**. It has been broken down by the rising power of **Rosavalda "Rose" Durst**, a trapped ghost in the House who is deeply troubled and angry with the situation in the cursed manor. Rose has been growing in spiritual power over the years, blessed with divine powers from the **Morninglord**, the god of the dawn and rebirth (also known as **Lathander** in other Planes). Rose now has accumulated enough power to challenge and rival that of the Death House.

Death House has lured a lost young woman, **Ireena**, within. This has become the last straw for Rose who has had enough of the House's evil through the years. Her intensifying anger and angst will summon heroes through the **Mists of Ravenloft** to the House. Not only must they rescue Ireena in the malevolent House, but they must also escape the vengeance and fury of Rose against the House as the two supernatural forces battle within. All this must be accomplished before the House traps every soul inside and collapses at the stroke of midnight.

Death House's Features

Death House (CE **haunting revenant**) is a cognizant creature, fully aware of its immediate environment within Barovia and all creatures within the house and dungeon. These revenants lurk in plain sight, waiting for their foes to near, then trap their victims within their massive bodies. Those inside a haunting revenant might be battered by animate furnishings or more unsettling manifestations of the revenant's hatred.

As in the original mini-adventure, **Death House** has four stories (including the attic), with two balconies on the third floor—one facing the front of the house, the other facing the back. The house has wooden floors throughout, and all windows have hinges that swing outward.

Ceilings differ in height by floor. The first floor has 10-foot-high ceilings, the second floor has 12-foot-high ceilings, the third floor has 8-foot-high ceilings, and the attic has 13-foot-high ceilings. The dungeon level has 8-foot-high ceilings and is co-located wherever the house sits in Barovia. It is considered a part of the House and likewise can change with each reincarnation.

The characters can burn the House to the ground if they want, but the House is immortal. It can revive in 24 hours at a different location unless a *Dispel Evil and Good* is cast (causing it to revive in thirteen years).



Into The Mists

The Call to Adventure

At first, all you remember from the autumn harvest festival in the woods is the bonfire. Then other details become less fuzzy in the dim dusk light. The dancing crowd of people dressed as spirits of the departed dead. The sacrifice of crops and livestock to the gods as you feasted and drank.

You faintly remember laughing at the old blind bard who spun a tale of how the borders between worlds were thinned and the dead walked among the living. The old bard looked at you, seeming to look through you with those milky white orbs, and strangely laughed back at you. As the afternoon waned, you felt peculiar before you napped against a tree... unwell.

The woods are now oddly quiet and the air grows chill as dusk settles in. The fire sputters; a low mist obscures everything around you, turning the trees into gray ghosts. Then you notice these are not the same trees that surrounded you earlier this afternoon.

Roleplay Opportunity: If the character(s) look around, it's obvious that they have somehow stepped between worlds. If the characters are together but unacquainted with one another, give them the opportunity to get acquainted. Have the players describe their own character to one another, share a quirk they might have, and roleplay the puzzling situation they find themselves in. When you are ready, proceed on:

As the dim dusk light fades to the twilight of early evening, a blood-curdling scream echoes through the woods. The terror, angst, and anger contained in it reverberates and seems to cause the mists to briefly part, revealing a dark, twisted path through the ghostly trees to a dilapidated manor house in the distance.

The scream has supernaturally emanated from the ghost of Rosavalda "Rose" Durst to summon the heroic travelers through the **Mists** to her aid in rescuing Ireena from the House.

Approaching the House

As the characters approach the House, read:

The path that beckons you is no ordinary trail. It winds through the twisted trunks of ancient oaks, their bark etched with runes long lost to time. The leaves crunch underfoot, releasing a musty aroma. The moon, a pale full orb, casts elongated shadows that dance across the path, as the mist obscures your journey.

Suddenly, a raven's wings slice through the air, its croak resonates, an echo that seems to mock your intrusion into this forsaken realm. You shudder, your breath crystallizing in the chill, and wonder if the raven is a harbinger of your descent into darkness.

The manor house looms before you, its brick facade a testament to time's inexorable march. Each brick bears the weight of centuries, sagging under the burden of secrets long past. The windows, once eyes to the soul of the house, now gape like hollow sockets, their glass shattered by unseen forces. The shutters, like ancient eyelids, hang askew, their hinges rusted and protesting against the passage of years. Four floors rise from the ground, each level a chapter in the manor's tragic tale. That scream—a girl's scream—lingers in the air here, a spectral imprint etched into your mind. You wonder what tragedy unfolded here; what malevolence still clings to the house.

A massive cliffside rises from the woods nearby to a startling height of 1,000 feet. On top of this cliff, you see the walls and towers of an ancient castle through flashes of lightning as the weather quickly worsens.

The rusted front gate to the house creaks as the wind causes it to sway back and forth. Each squeak grates on your now high-strung nerves as the mists and drizzling rain make you drift into a dark mood.

Characters who remain outside the House can see the **Mists** close in around them, swallowing up the rest of the area. As more of the woods disappear into the Mists, the characters are left with little choice but to seek refuge in the House. The Mists stop short of entering the House but engulf anyone outside. If the characters attempt to leave or circumvent the House, the Mists return them to the Portico (Area 1A) in a state of **exhaustion**. **It is now 6 p.m.**



The Mists of Ravenloft

The Mists of Ravenloft are a dense fog that surrounds the region of Barovia and engulfs any creature that tries to leave. They are used as a story device to move characters from their home worlds to Barovia. The fog's effects can be harmful and deadly, which are as follows:

- A creature that starts its turn in the fog must succeed on a **DC 20 Constitution Saving Throw** or gain one level of **exhaustion**. This **exhaustion** can't be removed while the creature is in the fog.
- No matter how far a creature travels in the fog, or in which direction it goes, it gets turned around so that it eventually finds itself back near the Death House.
- The area within the fog is **heavily obscured** (*See also* "**Blinded**," "**Darkness**," and *Player's Handbook* chapter 1 ("Exploration")).

Fear and Mental Stress

Fear

When even stern adventurers confront threats that are supernaturally frightful, you can call for them to make a **Wisdom Saving Throw**. The module sets the DC according to the circumstances. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. The character can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of his or her turns, ending the effect on the character on a successful save. If a player roleplays the fear well, you may choose to spare their character from making a saving throw.

Mental Stress (Horror)

Horror involves more than simple fright. It entails revulsion and anguish. In such a situation, you can call on characters to make a **Wisdom Saving Throw** to resist the **mental stress effects**.

Resting in Death House

Should the characters choose to take a **short** or **long rest** in **Death House**, they **will be haunted** (100% chance). With each attempted rest and haunting, move to the next number in sequence to make the hauntings progressively dark and intimidating. Since time is of the essence, **resting will be interrupted** by the House and the characters will be forced to continue until the adventure is completed.

Resting in Death House Haunting Sequence

Order	Haunting
1.	A character wakes to feel a small spider crawling on their face, its sticky webbing on their mouth and nose.
2.	A character hears scurrying, tiny squeaks, and scratching noises from a nearby wall.
3.	A character wakes up to hear the sound of a small boy crying somewhere in the house.
4.	A character is shocked awake as a high-pitched, blood-curdling scream emanates somewhere close to their resting position. They suddenly realize that it came from themself.
5.	A character is nudged awake by a non-combative, translucent **ghost** of the former nursemaid, Brigetta. Unable to speak, she is franticly trying to warn the character to leave the House.
6.	A character is unable to move. They are paralyzed, shackled, and dangling above a dark altar while thirteen shadowy apparitions chant in growing volume and unison, "One must die. One must die! ONE MUST DIE!" The character wakes in a cold sweat. It was just a nightmare... or was it a memory? It was so real!





Within Death House

Areas of the House

The following areas correspond to labels on the map of the house found in *Curse of Strahd*, *Appendix B*. Numerous map resources exist and can be used (even virtual table top), although the décor has changed in some areas of the House. An exterior map of the house is provided as an attachment JPG and included in **Appendix B**.

DM's Option: Timing the Exploration and Escape. A quick way of using time is to give each floor explored roughly one hour. Have the clock (Area 6) chime (heard throughout the House and basement) each hour. The adventure begins at **6 p.m**. This will pace the characters to have about four hours for the Manor House and two hours for the dungeon "basement" and escape. This will cause a time crunch to escape the House by midnight.

DM's Option: Slowing the Party—Trouble with the Doors. In this option, the House gives the characters trouble when they are opening doors. This gets progressively worse floor by floor. Using a crowbar grants an **advantage**.

First Floor: 10% chance, **DC 10 Strength** check.
Second Floor: 33% chance, **DC 11 Strength** check.
Third Floor: 67% chance, **DC 12 Strength** check.
Attic: 100% chance, **DC 13 Strength** check.



First Floor

1. Entrance

1A. Stone Portico.

> The groaning gate and covered archway evoke a sense of foreboding. The rain and mists cling to the stone, making it appear as if the very walls weep.
>
> Dead leaves and stone debris litter the entrance, a testament to the passage of time. A chandelier, once resplendent, now lies shattered, its crystals scattered like lost memories.
>
> Those iron-framed, full-length stained-glass doors—what stories they must hold! The angelic figure depicted has faded, its divine beauty now fractured by the elements. Perhaps it once guarded against darkness, but now it merely invites it within.
>
> The decorative doorbell pullcord, once a link to the servants' domain, now rests in a pile of neglect. Its frayed edges tell tales of countless tugs, summoning attendants who have long since departed.

This area is about 25 feet from the balcony on the third floor, above (Area 12C). The double doors are unlocked and seem to barely hang on their hinges.

> The gate abruptly slams shut behind you, the sound reverberating through the portico and the manor beyond. It's as if the house itself has drawn you in. Is it a trap or an invitation? Perhaps both.
>
> Your stomach churns—an instinctive warning. The mist beyond the gate swirls, inscrutable and thick. The path and the woods vanish, swallowed by the fog.
>
> All that is left is to move into the waiting darkness of the manor house... but, are you a guest or an intruder?

The gate has locked itself (normal or magical attempts to unlock it **will fail**) until Rose unlocks and opens it for **The Great Escape**. Anyone outside is subject to the **Mists**.

1B. Grand Foyer.

> The foyer was perhaps once grand, but now looks like a tornado swept through it. Dead leaves crunch under your feet, making you cringe from the loud sounds. A variety of paintings have fallen from the dank mahogany-paneled walls down to a once decorative red carpet that has become torn and shredded with age and discolored with mildew.
>
> A thick pair of hard wood doors at the end of the hall lead further into the manor.

Paintings. If the characters choose to investigate the paintings, a successful **DC 10 Intelligence** (Investigation) **check** reveals that the central focus of each painting is a dark manor house in the distance. The master Barovian painters are from different centuries and the house appears to be the same but in different locales: within a village, an open field, a wooded clearing, a graveyard, atop a cliff, or beside a small country stream.

2. Main Hall

2A. Wide Hall Haunting:

> The ornate wooden doors open upon a massive hall that spans the entire width of the house. You are momentarily stunned to see the white marble floors sparkle from the central chandelier light and the reddish-brown mahogany walls glisten, recently oiled. An elaborately decorated white marble fireplace on the north wall is lit, casting an otherworldly glow on the hall. An ornate longsword, with a windmill cameo worked into its hilt, is mounted above the mantle.
>
> Several nobles dressed in fine attire stop their snobbish conversations to glare at your intrusion. At the southern end of the grand hall is a red marble staircase that rises magnificently to the floor above. From there, a tall butler makes his way to you, balancing a tray of wine glasses.
>
> "This is a PRIVATE, FORMAL-attire party, by invitation ONLY, with absolutely NO WEAPONS," he half-hisses at you, embarrassingly. He looks at you expectantly to surrender your weapons immediately as he sets down the tray on a nearby table.

Roleplay Opportunity: This is all an illusion generated by the **House** from its past memories. If the characters surrender their weapons, the butler (Wilhelm (benign), Aleko Dobromir's valet) will secure them in Area 2B, the cloakroom.

If the PCs fail to comply (they will because they don't have an invitation), argue with or attack Wilhelm, or ask about a scream from a young girl, the **House** will end the illusion abruptly, at your discretion:

> There is suddenly a fierce, bone-chilling gust of wind that blows through the hall from the fireplace, extinguishing all open and even protected (lantern) flames, plunging you into crushing darkness. You hear the solid thump of doors and shutters slamming shut throughout the house. Lastly, you hear the sound of a high-pitched scream and then… deafening silence.

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the characters make a **DC 10 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. Optionally, you can stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 10 Wisdom Mental Stress Saving Throw**.

When the characters manage to get illumination restored (or their *Darkvision* recovers), reveal the true condition of the hall:

> The proud hall you thought you saw is really in shambles. The mahogany paneling is rotting and the ceiling sags tiredly. The floor is cracked in several places, making you contemplate how safe it is to cross over it. The chandelier is fallen and lies shattered in a thousand pieces over the dusty floor.

Mantle Décor. The sword is not an illusion. The sword's blade will glow light blue in a five-foot radius when the sword hilt is touched. It is the Durst family's *+1 Longsword*.

2B. Cloakroom.

When the party tries to examine the cloakroom, reveal the following:

Haunting (What is Wrong with this Door?):

> You struggle to open the door to this closet; the handle moves easily and it is unlatched…is there someone trying to hold the door shut from the other side?
>
> Suddenly, the door slowly creaks open. There is the sound of a hideously insane laugh within. And then the door is wrenched from your hands and slams shut!

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the characters make a **DC 10 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. You can opt to stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 10 Wisdom Mental Stress Save**.

If the characters try to open the door again:

> You easily open the door to a small cloakroom, five-foot square with wooden pegs set into the cedar-lined walls. It smells of mildew, and oddly there is a dusty, old, silk top-hat lurking silently on the floor.

There is nothing of interest here unless Wilhelm has secured the party's surrendered weapons within (and you allow them to retrieve the weapons (see below)).

DM's Option: Death House Ate My Weapons! An option is to have the characters' weapons vanish in the cloakroom after Wilhelm places them here. This technique is used to unnerve and create anxiety in the horror setting. This can be especially stressful for beginning players, so it is recommended for more veteran players, at your discretion.

The characters will have to find various weapons that are placed throughout the House or find and use improvised weapons. You could also opt to have their weapons placed in the niches in Area 35 before they confront the final monsters in the dungeon.

3. Tea Room

The door creaks open on rusty hinges, revealing a small room that is black as pitch past your flickering light. Lightning crashes outside. As the clap of thunder booms through the creepy house, the details of the room are brought into bright relief.

A white-wood paneling made from tulip trees is hanging in peeled strips from the walls. Torn and yellowed lace curtains frame the grimy windows that are being pelted by the rain outside. Once beautiful woven tapestries depicting pleasant farmland scenes are tattered on the north and east walls.

Four cushioned chairs surround an ornate card table, all being constantly dripped on from the sagging ceiling above. A set of three couches encircle the unlit hearth, covered by dusty sheets. Delicate hand-painted tea cups lie in a shattered mess all over the floor.

The smell of decay hangs in the air, but beneath that you detect something else – a faint damp animal scent.

Haunting (Wolf Illusion):

Another flash of lightning illuminates the room. Movement, you're sure of it. A dark shape streaks along the edge of the wall towards you. You hear an inhuman snarl as the figure closes in.

There is nothing there but the memory of taxidermal wolves that once decorated this room. The House will use such hauntings and memories to build fear and horror.

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the characters make a **DC 10 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. You can opt to stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 10 Wisdom Mental Stress Save**.

A character may find a walking stick or cane propped up in a corner, usable for an improvised **quarterstaff** or **club**.

Border Ethereal Trapdoor. This trapdoor is concealed mystically by **Death House** in the southwestern corner of the room. It cannot be perceived or opened until the party approaches it from below (Area 32).

4. Kitchen and Pantry

4A. The Kitchen

This small kitchen is as dark as a crypt. As you step in, you feel and hear the crunch of broken glass underfoot. Apparently, it is from a lamp that was once stationed near the doorway. The dishware is shattered at the foot of a cabinet on the north wall, while a preparation table smells like something recently died upon it. Against the east wall, a brick, domed oven squats unlit, adjacent to a door that probably leads to a pantry. Labeled service bells are lined horizontally in a row along the west wall while a dumbwaiter sits all too quietly in the corner.

The kitchen is a disaster and the oven appears to be missing a few bricks. An iron pipe rises from the oven as a vent for the smoke, eventually exiting through the attic. A tenderizer mallet lying on the kitchen floor can become an improvised **club** or **mace**.

Preparation Table. There is a pool of congealed blood at the foot of the table, slowly dripping down from the table. The source of the blood is gone, but the eerie dripping sound continues. A rusty and dull **butcher's knife** is embedded in the cutting board and can be used as an improvised **dagger**.

Service Bells:

The bells seem to have once been attached to cords from the ceiling that when pulled used to cause a bell to dance on a spiraled metal coil. The labels below the bells (at eye-level) are now stained and difficult to read in the flowing script: Portico, Main Hall, Tea Room, Dining Hall, Study, Ball Room, Master Suite, Dumbwaiter-2, Dumbwaiter-3, and Attic.

The labels identify the location where the servants were to be summoned or where the dumbwaiter was to go.

The bells were once connected to cords that run to the various locations. The summoning pull cord in the rooms is often disguised as an ornate piece of window drapery or tapestry hanging near a window or fireplace. The cords have long since been disconnected from the bells.

Haunting (Attic Service Bell):

Suddenly, the crisp, clear chime of a small bell pierces the silence, sending a jolt of apprehension through you. Your eyes dart to the service bells, and there it is—the "Attic" bell, eerily swaying, then abruptly coming to a halt. But the cord... the cord isn't attached...

A chill creeps up your spine, a cold whisper of dread that seems to coil around your bones.

Rose is trying to summon the party to her location in the attic (Area 20).

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the characters make a **DC 10 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. You can opt to stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 10 Wisdom Mental Stress Save**.

Dumbwaiter:

Opening the sliding panel to the dumbwaiter, you notice that it must be on the third floor, above. A network of cables run down the corners of the tight, two-foot-square stone shaft. It appears to be a simple rope-and-pulley system that operates from a geared mechanism in the bottom of the shaft, attached to switches on the wall beside the opening, marked with the desired floor.

The shaft connects to Areas 7A (the servants' quarters) and 12A (the master bedroom). A small character can squeeze into the box with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check**.

The small elevator's rope-and-pulley mechanism is weakened and now can only support 100 pounds of weight before breaking. A character in the box when it falls **will** suffer (no save) 1d6 hit points per floor level (max 3d6) of falling and crushing damage. Once broken, the mechanism cannot be repaired without extensive work and resources only acquired in the Village of Barovia.

4B. Chilled Pantry

The confined pantry is surprisingly chilled, but it is a complete ruined disaster. The shelves are stocked with broken wine bottles, spilled spices, and sacks torn open with flour, wheat, sugar, and salt spread over rotting onions and potatoes. Wooden boxes packed with putrefied fruits and vegetables are in a shamble along the bottom shelves. Various smashed ceramic jars and bottles once containing cooking oils, sauces, milk, cream, cheese, tea leaves, butter, nuts, and dried pastas are spoiled, scattered, and smeared on the shelves. The meat hooks hold the impaled rotted remains of animal corpses, their dried blood covering the floor. The stench alone is enough to make you involuntarily retch and gag.

The chill is produced by a permanent enchantment placed upon this room, keeping it perfectly at 40°F/ 4°C. The stench is enough to make a character sick in this room, and each minute they spend in here have them make a **DC 15 Constitution Saving Throw** or become physically ill. Once they leave, they will recover in 2 (1d4) minutes.

Haunting (Locked in the Freezer):

As you step deeper into the pantry, the door suddenly slams shut. When you go to check it, it refuses to open, sealed tight as the cold begins to crystalize your breath and settle into your bones.

No means of physical strength will open the door. The House means to scare the character and after all seems hopeless in their chilled claustrophobia (and likely sickness from the stench), the door will suddenly open.

DM's Option: Mental Stress Save. Have the trapped character make a **DC 10 Wisdom Saving Throw**. On a failed save, the character either takes 3 (1d6) hit points of psychic damage or gains a short-term or long-term **mental stress** effect that you select or determine randomly.

5. Dining Room

Flashes of lightning outside glint off the crystal chandelier, casting prisms of color over the mahogany table and eight cushioned chairs. Lace drapes frame the windows and match the white-wood paneling and the ivory-colored cushioning on the chairs.

The table is formally set with polished silverware precisely positioned around ornate dinner plates and crystal glasses. Crisp, white cotton dinner napkins are folded expertly upon each place setting. Empty serving pitchers, crystal decanters, and a large crystal punch bowl sit on a small serving table located by the hall entrance and near the clean, white-marble fireplace.

Lastly, a magnificent tapestry of an angelic court surrounding the Morninglord adds a sense of serenity to the immaculate formal dining room.

This is not an illusion. The room is meticulously spotless and highly organized, set for a formal dinner.

Treasure. The silverware and crystalware here are worth 500 gp total.

The Tapestry:

The woven fabric of the tapestry is exquisite, truly a masterwork. The angel court décor ties all of the artistry on this floor into a theme of divine justice.

Haunting (Tapestry Falls):

As you begin to examine the tapestry closer, the woven material seems to shake and then to plunge downwards, lapping and overlapping in curls at your feet. Looking up, you are startled to see that the iron rod it was hanging from is hurtling towards your head!

Dodging the rod will require a successful **DC 10 Dexterity Saving Throw** or it causes 3 (1d6) hp bludgeoning damage.

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the character make a **DC 10 Wisdom saving throw**. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. You can opt to stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 10 Wisdom Mental Stress Save**.

Second Floor

The red marble staircase that started on the first floor (Area 2) climbs to Area 6 and continues its upward spiral to Area 11. A cold draft flows down the steps.

6. Upper Hall

This upper hall also spans the entire width of the house, while the majestic red-marble staircase continues its dizzying spiral to the third floor. Two sets of double-doors stand guard over the middle of the hall to the east and west, while a solitary door leads just off the staircase to the east. Standing suits of armor clutching spears flank the doors.

Above the fireplace mantle sits an oil painting of a noble family. Just below the picture, a clock rests, and a rhythmic ticking echoes through the hall.

Painting:

Hanging above the mantelpiece is an aged and torn wood-framed portrait. The labeling plate reveals the picture is of the Durst family: Gustav and Elisabeth Durst with their two smiling children, Rose and Thorn. Cradled in the father's arms is a swaddled baby, Walter, which the mother regards with a hint of scorn.

Clock. Use the clock to remind the player(s) of the current time. The chimes for each hour can be heard mystically throughout the House and Dungeon levels. If the characters spent one hour on the first floor, it should chime **7 p.m.** now.

Armor. The armor at the moment is purely decorative (but will be animated by the House during the escape and will encounter the party in Area 2, see **The Great Escape**).

The four (4) **spears** that they hold may be easily taken on this initial investigation and used by the characters. If they are taken, the **animated armor** will not have the spears when they attack during **The Great Escape**.

7. Servants' Quarters

Ah, the servants' quarters—the air here hangs heavy with memories, and the creaking floorboards seem to echo the footsteps of those who once toiled in service.

Two beds, their wooden frames worn and sagging, tell tales of countless nights spent in restless slumber. At the foot of each bed is a footlocker, their leather handles frayed and hinges rusted, guarding secrets—perhaps letters, trinkets, or keepsakes?

The cracked-open closet door beckons, revealing a glimpse of the past. The servant formal attire, moth-eaten and faded, hangs like ghosts on wire hangers.

And there, in the corner, stands the dumbwaiter shaft—an ancient contraption that once ferried meals and messages between floors. Its wooden panels bear the scars of countless journeys, and its pulley system remains frozen in time. The shaft waits, as if holding its breath, in a lonely melancholy.

7A. Bedroom:

The footlockers are empty except for a dried ink pot, old quill, a few sheets of parchment, and a hurried, unfinished letter:

Dearest Mother,

I'm scared here in this house. Though at times it can be bright and cheerful and the Master is gentle and kind, I have seen and heard things here that make me question my sanity. I've decided to return home immediately, and no, it is not due to homesickness!

7B. Closet:

The uniforms are the typical drab, Barovian aristocrat servant formal-wear. There are black dresses with gray-colored sashes, accented with lace frills at the collars and cuffs. Otherwise, the closet is dusty and cobwebs have taken over the corners.

Dumbwaiter. A dumbwaiter in the corner of the west wall has a button on the wall next to it. Pressing the button used to ring the bell in Area 4A.

8. Law Office

Lightning continues to flash through the yellowed lace curtains that frame the windows, casting wild shadows around the room. It is obvious that this room was designed to be a barrister's comfortable study of his art: Barovian Law.

A pair of plush leather chairs flank the white marble fireplace where an alabaster statuette of blind Lady Justice oversees the room from the mantle. A dusty yet decorative mahogany desk and lavish wing-backed chair sit near the windows.

The truly impressive mark of this room is the floor to ceiling book shelves with massive law volumes filling every gap possible and still some reside on the floor. The 12-foot-high rolling ladder is a convenient furnishing.

Eerie Silence. The entire chamber is enchanted with a permanent *Silence* spell. No sound can be created within or pass through this room except the hourly clock chime. Any creature or object entirely inside the room is immune to thunder damage, and creatures are **deafened** while entirely inside it. Casting a spell that includes a verbal component is impossible within.

The Desk. The desk has a few items resting on top of it: a silver candlestick holder, a silver letter-opener, a jar of ink, and a quill pen. Inside the desk drawer is a letter kit containing ten blank sheets of parchment.

The Bookshelves. The bookshelves hold hundreds of law tomes including (but certainly not limited to, be creative):

- *Barovian Law and Religious Devotion*
- *Law As an Institution Against the Vistani Incursion*
- *Criminal Law Inquests and Scientific Inquiry*
- *Quickly Writing a Last Will and Testament in Barovia*
- *Consolidated Library of Barovian Law and Practice Through the Centuries* (250 volume set)



Secret Door. A successful **DC 11 Intelligence** (**Investigation**) **check** reveals a secret door behind the bookshelf on the south wall. It can be unlocked and swung open by pulling on a switch disguised to look like a red-spined book with the title: *Secret Doors and How to Find Them*. Beyond the secret door hides Area 9.

Haunted Trap (Cold Spot) (Haunted Trap Bonus +2): The character who pulls on the red-spined book is subjected to an increasing plummeting of temperature (haunted trap emanation). The character notices the emanation if their **passive Wisdom** (**Perception**) score equals or exceeds 11.

All creatures within a five-foot radius are affected as if they had been outside in freezing cold weather for 1 hour, taking 1d6 points of cold damage unless they succeed at a **DC 11 Constitution Saving Throw**. The cold temperature lingers for 10 minutes, but has no additional effect.

A character who notices the haunted trap has until the start of their next turn to react, which might include fleeing to avoid the trap or attempting to disarm it.

To use Channel Divinity to disarm a haunted trap, a character uses an action to present their holy symbol and speak a prayer. To use *Remove Curse* instead, a character must cast the spell and touch the red-spined book.

Whichever disarming method is used, the trap itself then makes a saving throw against the character's spell save DC, adding its Haunt Bonus (+2) to the save. On a failure, the trap is disarmed for 24 hours. If the trap fails the save by 10 or more, the trap is disarmed permanently.

9. Secret Room

The bookshelf slowly rolls open on a set path, but pushes back as if it desires to close back into the shelving. It reveals a cluttered closet with grimy shelves crammed with unreadable, rotting tomes embellished with archaic characters. A black, heavy chest crouches at the end of the narrow room, its lid partially opened. Hunched over and halfway into the chest is a human skeleton in leather armor.

Unless the secret door is propped open, springs in the hinges will cause it to close on its own.

Bookshelves. These tomes once described bogus fiend-summoning and necromantic rituals of the Durst **Cult of Strahd**. They now rot beyond readability, crumbling at the touch.

Chest. Close inspection reveals that the skeleton belongs to a human who triggered a poisoned dart trap. Three darts are stuck in the dead adventurer's leather armor and ribcage. The dart-firing mechanism inside the chest no longer works. The skeleton holds a shortsword in its right hand.

Clutched in the skeleton's left hand is a letter bearing the seal of Strahd von Zarovich, which the unfortunate adventurer tried to remove from the chest. Written in flowing script, the letter reads as follows:

My most pathetic servant,

I am not a messiah sent to you by the Dark Powers of this land. I have not come to lead you on a path to immortality. However many souls you have bled on your hidden altar, however many visitors you have tortured in your dungeon, know that you are not the ones who brought me to this beautiful land. You are but worms writhing in my earth.

You say that you are cursed, your fortunes spent. You abandoned love for madness, took solace in the bosom of another woman, and sired a stillborn son. Cursed by darkness? Of that I have no doubt. Save you from your wretchedness? I think not. I much prefer you as you are.

Your dread lord and master,

Count Strahd von Zarovich

Treasure. The chest contains three blank books with black leather covers (worth 25 gp each), three ***Spell Scrolls*** (*Remove Curse*, *Protection from Poison*, and *Lesser Restoration*), the deed to the house, the deed to a windmill, and a signed will.

The windmill referred to in the second deed is situated in the mountains east of Vallaki ("**Old Bonegrinder**"). The will is signed by Gustav and Elisabeth Durst and bequeaths the house, the windmill, and all other family property to Rosavalda and Thornboldt Durst in the event of their parents' deaths. The documents will age markedly if taken from the house but remain intact.

You could optionally include a common weapon inside the chest that the party needs if Death House "ate" the characters' weapons.

Haunting (Illusory Poisoned Darts):

As you remove the items from the chest, you are suddenly struck in the torso three times, simultaneously, from different directions. You feel like you have been pierced but you see no physical sign of it. A wave of nausea assaults you and your head swims. Panic fills you and you have the urgent desire to flee, to escape. You feel like you are about to black out.

These symptoms are illusory and will fade in 2 (1d4) minutes with no physical damage to the character.

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the "poisoned" character make a **DC 11 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails the save becomes **frightened** for 1 minute. Optionally, you can stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 11 Wisdom Mental Stress Saving Throw**.



10. Ballroom

This room once would have been breathtaking in sunlight, but the thunderstorm outside now casts a dark shroud on this decaying ballroom. Yellowed lace drapes frame the western windows while a central crystal chandelier remains dark above.

A harpsichord and standing harp watch each other sullenly across the ballroom from one another, the warped and cracked floors silently absent of guests.

The mantle of the shadowy, white-marble fireplace is graced by crystal angel figurines in various poses of refined dance. Empty mahogany, high-backed chairs with ivory-colored cushions are the silent onlookers to this lonely and dismal scene.

Instruments and Figurines. The instruments are in decaying condition and are far out of tune. Playing either of the instruments or touching the six crystal figurines (worth 25 gp each) will initiate the haunted trap, below.

Haunted Trap (Crystal Splinter Cloud) (Haunt Bonus +1): Every haunted trap has an emanation, which in this case is an angelic figurine moving of its own accord when a character sits down at an instrument or touches a crystal figurine. A character notices the emanation if their **passive Wisdom** (**Perception**) score equals or exceeds 11. Class features and spells, such as *Detect Evil and Good*, that discern desecration also detect haunted traps.

A character who notices the haunted trap has until the start of their next turn to react, which might include fleeing to avoid the trap or attempting to disarm it.

To use Channel Divinity to disarm a haunted trap, a character uses an action to present their holy symbol and speak a prayer. To use ***Remove Curse*** instead, a character must cast the spell and touch an object that is part of it.

Whichever disarming method is used, the trap itself then makes a saving throw against the character's spell save DC, adding its Haunt Bonus (+1) to the save. On a failure, the trap is disarmed for 24 hours. If the trap fails the save by 10 or more, the trap is disarmed permanently.

As you watch in stunned silence, the crystal angel figurines first begin to tremble, then shake, then fall one by one to the marble base of the fireplace, shattering horrifically into millions of sharp shards.

The air thickens, and the shards of the shattered angel figurines rise and hang suspended, glinting like malevolent stars. You feel a pull, an inexplicable force urging you to escape. The hall suddenly stretches in your vision, elongating into infinity, the doors impossibly far away. The walls pulse with a heartbeat that isn't your own.

The shards congeal into a crystalline cloud, flying through the long hall, piercing everything in their path... and you are in their path!

Dodging the splinter cloud and exiting the room will require a successful **DC 11 Dexterity Saving Throw** or receive 9 (3d6) hit points of slashing and piercing damage. Unless permanently disarmed, the cloud will remain swirling in the room for one hour before reforming into the angel figurines on the mantle once again.

Third Floor

If the PC(s) spent one hour on the second floor, the clock should chime **8 p.m.** throughout the House now.

11. Balcony Hall

The creaking red-marble staircase wearily carries you to its final floor, a balcony that overlooks the spiraled height of the stairs from the third floor. The ceiling is lower here, making it feel like it may fall and crush you easily at its whim. The air is thick with dust. Facing the balcony railing is a full-size marble statue of a young girl angel. A few solitary doors are visible through the balcony hallway with a set of double doors at the end of the hall to the east.

Marble Angel Statue:

This massive piece of magnificent artwork is highly detailed. It must have taken several workers and an engineer with a marvelous mechanism to get it here.

If the party saw the Durst family portrait (Area 6), they will recognize the angel as a statue of Rosavalda "Rose" Durst. Otherwise, they will have to wait until they reach Area 20 until they can make the connection.

Secret Door to the Attic Staircase: A successful **DC 12 Intelligence** (Investigation) **check** will reveal the secret door. If the party is having trouble finding either door, you may have Rose cause it to open a crack that will be seen, feel a cold draft coming from it, and hear a loud creak.



12. Master Suite

12A. Master Bedroom

The grimy stained glass on the double doors depicts an angel in repose, at peace, drifting on sunlit clouds among the birds of the air. The doors creak open on rusty hinges to a once luxurious master suite. Rain pelts the windows and you still hear the distant grumblings of thunder.

Investigating further, a rare white-tiger skin rug rots on the floor near the crumbling fireplace. Above it is a humble portrait of a lawyer in his finery, creases of worry on his bald forehead and around his spectacled eyes. A sturdy roll-top desk is littered with paperwork, at a glance they appear to be bills from some sort of home renovation.

A sagging four-poster bed dominates the chamber and the bedding is soiled and dingy, completing the dismal and depressing picture.

The adjacent parlor is cobwebbed in melancholy, a few dusty law tomes lying open on the table. The dumbwaiter gapes open in the corner, slack-jawed as it reveals the empty wooden transport box inside.

Churning gusts of rain and wind cause the wooden balcony door to clatter in protest, as if the weather is about to burst in like a bandit.

The Desk:

The total cost of this renovation must have been staggering, even a quick tally brings it in at well over 100,000 gp! A personal letter in a flowing aristocratic script catches your eye.

My dear servant Aleko Dobromir,

Since the Durst family has abandoned the House with no living heirs, the property has been reclaimed by my estate.

Enclosed you will find the deed to the House that I'm sure you will agree is not only full payment for your humble barrister services to my estate, but also a deserving reward for your good deeds and charity to my beloved people and the church.

Such a grand House, once renovated of course, will certainly make you the envy of the aristocracy and perhaps someday soon grant your rightful place amongst our number.

Your Lord and Master,

Count Strahd Von Zarovich

The most recent house deed is in the desk drawer, a legal document granting Aleko Dobromir the house, signed by Strahd and sealed legally with his **sigil** in red wax. The desk drawer also holds an iron key, which unlocks the door to Area 20.

Dumbwaiter. The empty dumbwaiter box and mechanism in the corner of the west wall has a button on the wall next to it. Pressing the button used to ring the tiny bell in Area 4A.

12B. Closet

The closet is filled with Aleko Dobromir's clothes and shoes, all of them of somber Barovian custom. They are dusty and moth-eaten.

12C. Balcony

The pelting rain and thick mist obscures everything past the ornate iron railing of this small balcony. You can barely view the ground some twenty-five feet below.

Exiting the House over the balcony without going through **The Great Escape** will subject the deserter(s) to the **Mists**. After hopeless meandering, they will find themselves back inside the portico (Area 1), in a state of **exhaustion**.

13. Bath Chamber

It has been a while since you have seen the extravagance of indoor plumbing, but here it is in all of its glory. A beautiful, white porcelain tub rests on brass clawed feet, with matching sink and privy! A clay mug sits on the back ledge of the sink with a toothbrush and razor sitting within. Sitting next to the mug is a large bar of lye soap.

The room smells faintly of bleach and the ceramic-tiled floor is in a checkered black and white pattern. Clean, white-cotton hand and bath towels rest on brass rods near the sink and bath tub.

The most amazing feature of this room is that the water is delivered through pipes not only cold, but also to a separate *hot* spigot! Drains carry all of the waste and dirty water away in an engineering marvel.

This is illusory. If a character decides to investigate further, read the following haunting:

Haunting (Nursemaid Murder Scene):

The room twists horribly in your vision, causing vertigo as the marvelous chamber becomes a dark, horrifying scene. A young woman in nursemaid attire lies rotting and dead in the tub, filled with her own blood. Bloody, desperate hand marks cover the walls and tub near her. The floor is likewise covered in her blood, the awful plink sound of it dripping over the edge of the tub and onto the floor. The look on her face is complete terror. It is obvious that she was horribly murdered here. The stench is overwhelming and sickening, driving you out from the room, slipping on her slick blood.

DM's Option: Mental Stress Save. Have those in the room make a **DC 12 Wisdom Saving Throw**. On a failed save, the character gains a short-term or long-term **mental stress** effect that you choose or determine randomly. This is the scene where members of the Durst's **Cult of Strahd** murdered Brigetta, the nursemaid, who had an affair with Mr. Durst and had a stillborn son (Walter).

If the character(s) reenter the room, the scene is gone. It will contain a cobwebbed and rotting, mildewed wooden tub with clawed feet, a small iron stove with a kettle resting atop it, and a barrel under a spigot in the east wall. A cistern on the roof used to collect rainwater, that was borne down a pipe to the spigot; however, the plumbing no longer works.

14. Cleaning Storage Room

The door screeches open onto a dusty storage closet. Once clean folded linens (towels and bedding), blankets, pillows, and bars of soap sit on the shelves. A cobwebbed broom leans against the far wall, near fireplace-ash and floor-scouring buckets. Old bleach, floor wax, and wood oil are stored in containers on the floor below the shelves.

Optional Combat Encounter (Low Difficulty): If you wish to add some optional humor *and* you have time, you may have the **feather pillow(s)** attack (with the same stats as a **broom of animated attack**, except they only cause 0-1 hit point of bludgeoning damage when they hit). The number of pillows is at your discretion, but one feather pillow per character seems only fair. They will leave quite a mess when "killed."

15. Steward's Suite

15A. Head Servant's Quarters.

Durst History: The bedroom once belonged to the family's nursemaid, Brigetta (benign). Gustav Durst and Brigetta had an affair, which led to the birth of a stillborn baby named Walter. The **Cult of Strahd** slew the nursemaid shortly thereafter (Area 13) and took her body to Area 38.

Dobromir History: The bedroom most recently belonged to the house butler, Wilhelm (benign), who also served as Aleko Dobromir's valet. His tragic fall was caused by the **Death House** while he was on the exterior balcony (Area 15C), falling to the ground at the portico (Area 1A).

As you step across the creaking floorboards into these servant quarters, the rain's relentless patter against the windowpanes and balcony doors seems to echo the room's forlorn emptiness. The bed, once grand, now sags under the weight of time. Decaying nightstands stand sentinel, their surfaces marred by rings from long-forgotten cups of tea or inkwells.

Meanwhile, a wardrobe, a relic of forgotten fashion, stands open like a yawning mouth. Dust motes dance in the dim light, and cobwebs cling to its corners.

Lastly, a full-length mirror, framed in ivy and berries, reflects a distorted image. It is ancient and weathered, the glass old and wavy.

Mirror Haunted Trap (Faceless Malice) (Haunt Bonus +2): This haunted trap affects a 15-foot-cube in front of the ornate mirror hanging on the wall. When a visible creature enters the area, the trap's emanation manifests as the creature's distorted reflection in the mirror. A character notices the emanation if their **passive Wisdom (Perception)** score equals or exceeds 12. Characters who inspect the mirror can, with a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check**, notice eyeballs among the berries, and they will also see the trap's emanation. Class features and spells, such as *Detect Evil and Good*, that discern desecration also detect this haunted trap.

A character who notices the haunted trap has until the start of their next turn to react, which might include fleeing to avoid the trap or attempting to disarm it.

If that creature is still in the area at the start of its next turn, it must succeed on a **DC 12 Wisdom Saving Throw** or be **blinded**, **deafened**, and rendered unable to speak for 1 minute.

Additionally, an illusion makes it appear that the creature has had its face erased. After a creature fails its saving throw against the trap, the trap won't activate again for 24 hours.

The *Remove Curse* spell ends this effect, as does Channel Divinity, and destroying the mirror. Whichever disarming method is used, the trap itself then makes a saving throw against the character's spell save DC, adding its Haunt Bonus (+2) to the save. On a failure, the trap is disarmed for 24 hours. If the trap fails the save by 10 or more, the trap is disarmed permanently. If destroying the mirror, it has AC 12, 10 hit points, vulnerability to bludgeoning damage, and immunity to poison and psychic damage.

Secret Door to the Attic Staircase: A successful **DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check** will reveal the secret door in the east wall behind the mirror. It is stuck, requiring a **DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check** to open. An **advantage** is given to the roll if a **crowbar** is used. It opens to expose a dusty staircase leading to the attic.

15B. Nursery

The door slowly creaks open, revealing a drab, lifeless room. An ebony shroud embellished with windmills covers a central crib. The translucent spirit of a slender blond woman in servant clothing floats near the door to the balcony, softly humming a lullaby as she stares out the window, completely unaware of your presence.

Benign Haunting: Brigetta. The nursemaid, **Brigetta**, is a non-combative **ghost**. If rudely treated or attacked, she screams in fright and vanishes ethereally. If approached with some politeness, she will shyly speak with the group.

Brigetta is confused, not remembering her death nor realizing that she is dead. If asked, she speaks respectfully of Mr. Durst, but will not mention their affair out of decorum. If the characters ask her directly about Walter's parentage, she states that it is not her place to speak of such things. Brigetta expresses clear affection for the children of the house. However, if Mrs. Durst is brought up in conversation, Brigetta will not speak negatively of the lady, but the characters will sense from her nonverbal language that she is terrified of Mrs. Durst.

Approaching the Crib. Brigetta freely lets the characters check the cradle once they have assured her of their good motives. When a character parts the shroud, they see a tightly wrapped, baby-sized bundle lying in the crib. Characters who unwrap the blanket find nothing inside it.

When Brigetta learns of the missing baby, she gasps in addled anxiety. "Walter? He must be with his brother and sister!" she exclaims. She then vanishes through the mirror in Area 15A in a distressed search of the attic.

Brigetta will eventually return here in an hour, forgetting her distress and even having met the characters.

15C. Balcony

The pelting rain obscures everything past the decorative iron railing of this small balcony. A bend in the west railing indicates where someone must have fell. You can barely see the stone portico some twenty-five feet below.

Examining the railing further, you surmise it must have taken quite a lot of force to cause such a thing to happen to the sturdy metal. You realize it was not a mere accidental tumble.

Exiting the House over the balcony without going through **The Great Escape** will subject the deserter(s) to the **Mists**. They will find themselves surprisingly back in the portico (Area 1), in a state of **exhaustion**.

Haunting (Phantom Jump Scare):

As you turn to leave the balcony there is a sudden flash of lightning. You are shocked to see the dark phantom of the butler nose-to-nose with you, a terrifying look in his eyes as his taloned fingers reach out for your throat, driving you instinctively backwards on the slick balcony surface!

DM's Option: Fear Save. This is an illusion, but have the attacked character make a **DC 12 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails is **frightened** for 1 minute. Optionally, you can stack failed Fear saves in a **DC 12 Wisdom Mental Stress Saving Throw**.

Also, if the PC failed the save, they will tumble over the railing (due to fear, rain, obscurity, and slick surface). Fortunately, **Brigetta** will immediately come to the aid of the character and pull them back onto the balcony to safety. She will appear to be exhausted from the effort, however, and slowly fade into the **border ethereal plane** for the next hour.

Attic

If the PC(s) spent one hour on the third floor, the clock should chime **9 p.m.** throughout the House now.

16. Entry Hall

Stairwell:

> Climbing the dusty stairs, thunder booms deafeningly overhead, shaking the attic as you enter. The rain is coming down in sheets, battering the roof overhead like a drum.

A successful **DC 13 Intelligence** (Investigation) **check** will reveal that the dust has been disturbed by the fall of someone (a Dobromir renovation worker) down the steps.

Haunting (Shove on the lead PC on the stairs up):

> As you make it to the top stair you feel a hard, bone-breaking slam into your chest. The force of it knocks the wind from your lungs! Gasping futilely for air, you nearly black out from the intensity.

Shove. The House supernaturally shoved the lead character, and they must make a **DC 13 Strength** (Athletics) or **DC 13 Dexterity** (Acrobatics) **check** (the player chooses the ability to use). If the character fails, the House will push them down the steps (into other characters) causing a chain reaction of 6 (2d6) hit points of force, falling, collision, and bludgeoning damage on the lead character and 3 (1d6) hit points of collision and bludgeoning damage for any others on the stairs (no save). This is a one-time event.

DM's Option: Fear Save. Have the lead character who was shoved make a **DC 13 Wisdom Saving Throw**. If they fail the save, they become frightened for 1 minute. Optionally, you can stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 13 Wisdom Mental Stress Saving Throw**.

Haunting (Padlock on the Door):

> Inside the attic, dust clouds rise to welcome you and cobwebs drape the corners and rafters. Four doors lead from the empty central hall. An old padlock hangs open from the slot in the clasp on the doorframe closest to you. You watch in stunned silence as it slowly locks itself, making a distinct clicking sound.

The House has made sure that the iron padlock now secures the door to Area 20. The iron key is located within the desk drawer in Area 12. Otherwise, a successful **DC 13 Dexterity** (Sleight of Hand) **check** with thieves' tools or **DC 13 Strength check** (using a crowbar will grant an advantage) will open the lock.

The door itself is also stuck, requiring a successful **DC 13 Strength check** (using a crowbar will grant an advantage) to open the door. The House is trying to make it difficult for the character(s) to reach Rose in a timely manner.

If there is still a lot of time, you may try to delay the characters further by roleplaying the addled Brigetta who is trying to protect the children from strangers. She knows the children's parents locked them in the attic to "protect" them from "the monster in the basement," and that they died from hunger.

17. Creepy Attic Bedroom

> The door sticks momentarily in protest before groaning open into a spare bedroom thick with dust and cobwebs. The furniture also appears spare, a mismatched menagerie of décor. The item that draws your attention the most is a rocking chair that is moving slightly, a creepy, cobwebbed doll reclines in it. A flash of lighting crosses the window and shatters the image momentarily. As your eyes readjust, you ponder: did the doll just wink at you?

This dust-choked room stores a slender bed, a night stand, a small iron stove, a writing desk with a stool, an empty wardrobe, and the rocking chair with the doll.

Haunting (Creepy Doll):

> As you turn to leave the creepy bedroom, a tingly chill runs down your spine and the hairs on the back of your neck rise. You distinctly hear the doll whisper in an eerie little girl voice, "Don't leave me here all alone! You can *stay* with me... *FOREVER*..."
>
> The doll's whisper echoes through the room, its words etching themselves into your mind. The air grows colder, and you feel an inexplicable weight pressing down on your chest. You glance back at the doll, its porcelain face twisted into a malevolent grin.

DM's Option: Fear Save. A character who hears the doll makes a **DC 13 Wisdom Saving Throw**. A character who fails the save becomes frightened for 1 minute. Optionally, you can stack failed Fear saves into a **DC 13 Wisdom Mental Stress Saving Throw**.



18. Attic Storage

> This is what an attic typically looks like: a pack-rat nest of old furniture shrouded in dusty and aging sheets—chairs, couches, coat racks, standing mirrors, and old dress designing mannequins doomed to stand vigil over the entire sad lot. A wooden trunk, its cover open, reveals a treasure trove of... more dusty sheets.

If the House ate the party's weapons, the characters could optionally find a needed improvised weapon or simple weapon among the attic furnishings or in a trunk. Brigetta's skeleton will not be present in a trunk (original adventure) however you may optionally continue the roleplaying encounter with her in this room.

Border Ethereal Secret Door *(see Area 21).* Any attempts to find this mystically concealed secret door without Rose's assistance are in vain and completely frustrated.

19. Spare Bedroom

Lightning crackles, striking the roof of the house here, burning a blackened hole in the attic roof and electrifying the air. Rain immediately follows through, quickly drenching the small iron stove. More flashes from the window reveal a slender bed, a nightstand, a rocking chair, and an empty wardrobe all covered in cobwebs and dust.

Optional Combat Encounter (Low Difficulty): You could opt to add a **giant spider** (and a **swarm of spiders** for stronger parties) hiding in the wardrobe, if you have time.

20. Children's Bedroom

As you step into the children's bedroom, a cold draft brushes against your skin. Two small beds lurk in each corner, away from the door, cobwebs draped over them like sinister shrouds. An open toybox with windmills painted on its sides holds a chaotic jumble of dolls with cracked eyes, lifeless stuffed animals, wooden soldiers with battle scars, carved horses with broken legs, and alphabet blocks spelling ominous words. Opposite the toybox stands a dollhouse, a chillingly accurate replica of the very structure you now find yourself in.

In the dim light, you notice a slender, young girl with black hair, pacing anxiously at the foot of the bed to the left. Her attire, drab Barovian fashion, hints at a bygone era. Her face, though eerily familiar, seems out of place in this world. Her most unsettling feature is her semitransparent form, like a specter trapped between worlds.

Her voice, the same as the scream you heard earlier, breaks the oppressive silence. "It is about TIME! We have no TIME to lose... you have to get her away from the monster and out of the House by MIDNIGHT!" Her words spill out quickly, charged with urgency and anger. As her agitation grows, the room's chill deepens, thunder booms ominously nearby, and the House's windows rattle violently, as if in the throes of an earth tremor.

Doll House. Characters who investigate the dollhouse find all the House's secret doors, including one in the attic leading to a spiral staircase (Area 21) that descends below the House. However, they may not be able to open them.

Roleplaying Rose

Roleplaying Opportunity: Now that the party has **FINALLY** arrived, **Rose** will share what she knows.

- Rose does not remember all of her past, but is aware that she is deceased and that she has a brother, father, mother, and nursemaid. She isn't worried about where they are. She visits with her brother Thorn frequently.
- Rose knows that there is a basement, and remembers being told of a monster in the basement by her parents, but has never seen the basement or monster.
- A traumatized teenaged girl, **Ireena**, came to shelter in the House earlier in the day, and Rose fears the monster in the basement has her and that is why she screamed for the characters to come and help.
- Rose knows that people can be trapped here forever if they don't get out by midnight. The characters must rescue Ireena from the monster, then get her out of the House, before midnight.
- The children's parents would lock them in their room to keep them safe while they dealt with the monster in the basement. **Brigetta**, the nursemaid, usually checked on them, but Rose has not seen her in a while.
- Her brother, Thornboldt "**Thorn**" (benign) is here in the attic bedroom, but right now he is hiding under his bed and won't come out until the party leaves (they can hear sniffles coming from under his bed).
- Rose can serve as a **sidekick** (SK) for a weaker party or for a duet (DM and solo player) adventure. **Thorn** will not tag along, but will seek out **Brigetta** the nursemaid (Area 15) while Rose is gone adventuring.
- Rose knows that she can avoid most combat by going ***Ethereal*** and will move to a safe position to attack.
- Rose will (at the very least) guide the party to Area 21 and open the secret door for them.
- **Personality traits:** pithy, smart, and sarcastic. If someone is in trouble, I'm always ready to lend help.
- **Ideal:** People deserve to be treated with dignity and respect.
- **Bond:** I protect those who cannot protect themselves.
- **Flaw:** I like being in charge and get angry when other people tell me what to do.

Rosavalda "Rose" Durst

Small Undead (Ghost (modified)), *Lawful Good*

AC 11 **Initiative** +1 (11)

HP 45 (10d8) Max 80

Speed 5 ft., Fly 40 ft. (hover)

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
STR	7	-2	-2	DEX	13	+1	+1	CON	10	+0	+0
INT	10	+0	+0	WIS	12	+1	+1	CHA	17	+3	+3

Resistances Acid, Bludgeoning, Cold, Fire, Lightning, Piercing, Slashing, Thunder

Immunities Poison, Radiant; Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained

Senses Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 11

Languages Common, Common sign language

CR 4 (XP 1,100; PB +2)

Traits

Ethereal Sight. Rose can see 60 feet into the Ethereal Plane when she is on the Material Plane.

Incorporeal Movement. Rose can move through other creatures and objects as if they were **Difficult Terrain**. She takes 5 (1d10) Force damage if she ends her turn inside an object.

Actions

Multiattack. Rose makes two Radiant Touch attacks.

Radiant Touch. *Melee Touch Attack:* +5 to hit (magical attack), reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 19 (3d10 + 3) radiant damage.

Healing Touch (3/Day). When Rose intentionally touches any creature (including herself) with this ability, the target magically regains 19 (3d10 + 3) hit points and is freed from any curse, disease, poison, blindness, deafness, fear, or mental stress effect.

Etherealness. Rose can cast the ***Etherealness*** spell, requiring no spell components and using Charisma as the spellcasting ability.

21. Secret Stairs

As Rose leads you by the hand, you feel a serene peace wash over you, and the storm that rages above the attic seems to grow distant. You enter the attic storage room and remarkably, now you can clearly see a dainty, child's gold necklace hanging from a hook to the right of the door.

"There's my necklace!" Rose exclaims with a smile.

Necklace. The necklace is ***The Holy Symbol of Dawn***, a divine focus of the **Morninglord**. It has the following abilities:

- While using the Channel Divinity Turn Undead feature, increase the difficulty of the undead save DC by 2.
- While wearing the necklace, a creature is under the effect of a *Protection from Evil and Good* spell against fiends and undead.

Retrieving it will open the secret door. Rose will give it to a good-aligned cleric, paladin, or character *unless* she is acting as the **sidekick** for a solo character/weaker party.

MILESTONE DEVELOPMENT

Opening the Secret Door. Once the door has been opened, each character receives:

- A heroic inspiration.
- One experience level. Let the players update their sheets while you update your records.
- Allow the characters to recover hit points, change spells, etc., as if they have been through a long rest.

Time to Take a Break?

This is also a good place to take a break or end the first session, if you are going to run the adventure over two sessions. If your group has been going slow but is having a good time, then bookmarking here to a second session is sensible and the finale doesn't have to be rushed. Even if it is timed, don't forget that having fun is the key.

Staircase. The staircase starts in the attic and descends 50 feet to the dungeon ("basement") to Area 22. Rose will not follow the characters unless she is a **sidekick**. If Rose is the sidekick, Thorn will seek out Brigetta in Area 15.

A cramped wooden staircase spirals down a dark shaft with walls of mortared stone. You find yourself holding your breath in order to keep the choking dust at bay, cobwebs sticking to your hands, your face, your hair. Unable to see past your extended hand, the stairs groan in creaky protest, rotted boards on the verge of breaking.

Just as you feel that you may pass out, the narrow stairs finally end in a short stone hallway that intersects in a "T" with a longer stone hallway.

(If Rose is with the Party): You finally remember to breathe. Rose looks completely unaffected and smiles sheepishly at you. It seems there are some benefits to being incorporeal after all.

Dungeon Features

The dungeon level ("basement") below **Death House** is excavated out of earth, clay, and rock. The tunnels are 4-feet-wide by 7-feet-high with timber braces at 5-foot intervals. Rooms are 8 feet tall and supported by thick wooden posts with crossbeams.

The only exception is Area 38, which has a 16-foot-high ceiling supported by stone pillars. Unless the characters have Darkvision they must provide their own light sources in the darkness of the dungeon.

As the characters investigate the dungeon, they will see centuries-old human (and other) footprints in the earthen floor leading in all directions. Water from the rainstorm will be dripping from the ceilings and walls making the floors muddy and walls slick (creating a disadvantage for **Strength (Athletics) climbing checks**) in most areas.

The metal gauntlets are "on" in the dungeon and **Death House** is done with trying to feed off the party's fears with hauntings. Unlike the Durst cult, **Death House** has the power to summon undead, former occupants, and fiends to do its bidding.

Resting in the Dungeon

Should the group choose to take a short or long rest in the dungeon, they will be assaulted by **crawling claw(s)** (number is at your discretion). The House's purpose is simply to prevent the characters from fully resting, enough to scare the characters awake. Only Area 31 is exempt from this attack during a very short rest (30 minutes is allowable in this situation due to the special holy/divine nature of the chamber), if the characters believe that they have adequate time.

If the character(s) spent one hour in the attic, the clock should chime **10 p.m.** throughout the House now.



22. Dungeon Level: Access

The short entry tunnel to the basement intersects into choices to the left and right, both heading into darkness and the sounds of dripping water.

The wooden spiral staircase from the attic ends here. A narrow tunnel stretches southward before branching east and west.

23. Durst Family Crypts

Several crypts have been cut from the stone, some sealed by heavy stone slabs, some left ajar. They are otherwise cold, dark, and enigmatic.

Each crypt is sealed with a stone slab except 23A and 23B. Removing a slab from its fitting requires a successful **DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check**; using a crowbar or something similar grants an advantage on the check. One other character can assist and the highest roll is used for the result. **Rose will not approve of any crypt opening.**

23A. Empty Crypt.
The blank stone slab meant to seal this crypt leans against a nearby wall. The crypt is empty.

23B. Walter's Crypt.
The stone slab meant to seal this crypt leans against a nearby wall. Etched into it is the name Walter Durst (the stillborn baby of Gustav and Brigetta). The crypt is empty.

23C. Gustav's Crypt.
The stone slab is etched with the name Gustav Durst. The chamber beyond contains a coffin atop a stone bier. The coffin is empty, but the crypt holds a *+1 Longbow* and a leather quiver containing 20 arrows. It also holds a heavy crossbow, a light crossbow, a hand crossbow, and 20 bolts for each weapon.

23D. Elisabeth's Crypt.
The stone slab is etched with the name Elisabeth Durst. The crypt contains a stone bier with an empty coffin atop it. The wall has slightly caved into the chamber from behind the coffin.

23E. Rose's Crypt.
The stone slab is etched with the name Rosavalda Durst. The chamber contains a coffin on a stone bier with her remains.

23F. Thorn's Crypt.
The stone slab is etched with the name Thornboldt Durst. The chamber beyond contains a coffin on a stone bier with his remains (and the remains of a creepy doll).



24. Morgue

This morbid room smells of death and decay. A wooden table near the entrance has been strangely burned. Scorched tufts of black fur create the shape of a hound, but there is no corpse. It smells like sulfur and brimstone.

Darkened recesses hold wooden pallets, each holding monstrosities that you have never seen before. They look like they are in the middle of a dissection or autopsy. Holding your nose, you are simply glad that they appear dead and are not moving.

A successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Religion)** or **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check** will reveal that the monsters are all of Abyssal origin: the burnt table once held a hell hound that combusted, while the pallets hold two dead dretch, and two dead manes. These are the remains of a battle between the cultists and summoned fiends on this level. The fiends' leader, a cambion, massacred the cultists (Area 25) and then escaped through an Abyssal gate.

25. Cultist Massacre

Small rivulets of water flow down the few stone steps into a large chamber that once served as living quarters with open, partitioned rooms. Each alcove though looks like they have been torn apart: straw, wood shards from pallets, and shattered chests are strewn chaotically around. The stench is awful. Four cultists in black robes lie unmoving and rotting on the floor, they appear to have been ripped to shreds. A fifth dead cultist is draped over a dark stone well that is the centerpiece of this macabre massacre scene.

Undead Combat Encounter (Low/Moderate Difficulty):
Weaker or Average Parties: The dead cultists will rise up as zombies when the characters are busy investigating the living quarters.
Stronger Parties: The dead cultists can alternatively rise up as a mixture of Strahd zombie(s) and normal zombies, at your discretion.

The Well. The well smells dank and moldy. The water is contaminated and unfit for consumption.

Treasure. In addition to some worthless personal effects, each chest's contents are now strewn in the various alcoves.

25A. This room contains 11 gp and 60 sp in a pouch made of human skin.

25B. This room contains three moss agates (worth 10 gp each) in a folded piece of black cloth.

25C. This room contains a black leather eyepatch with a carnelian (worth 50 gp) sewn into it.

25D. This room contains an ivory hairbrush with silver bristles (worth 25 gp).

25E. This room's chest is secured with a rusty iron padlock that can be picked with thieves' tools and a successful **DC 15 Dexterity check**. It contains a *Silvered Shortsword* (worth 110 gp) and *+1 Dagger*.

26. Hidden Spiked Pit

This pit has a cover constructed from material identical to the floor around it. A character who examines the floor and succeeds on a **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** notices a suspicious absence of footprints in this hallway. A character searching the floor for traps finds a 5-foot-long, 10-foot-deep pit hidden under rotted wooden planks. Once the pit trap is detected, the five-foot-wide section can be jumped or avoided.

When a creature steps on the cover (several rotted wood planks hidden under a thin layer of dirt), it breaks, causing the intruder to fall into the 10-foot-deep pit below. The pit has sharpened wooden spikes at the bottom. The first character to step on the cover falls through, landing **prone** and taking 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage from the fall plus 11 (2d10) piercing damage from the spikes.

The pit is muddy and the walls are slick from the rainstorm outside, creating a **disadvantage** to climb out (**DC 15 Strength (Athletics) climbing check**) without assistance (critical fail = fall back in and take damage).

27. Bone Hall

> As you enter this hall every step is littered with crushed bone. It powders like a fine mist, obscuring your vision. Partially devoured kills are stored here, portions of the carcasses scattered along the tunnel. The scent of blood and rotting flesh hangs heavy in the air. A broken table and a pair of smashed benches adds to the scene of carnage.

In the middle of the south wall is a dark alcove (Area 28).

28. Barrels of Blood

> This was perhaps a larder or food pantry at some time, but now it holds barrels filled with blood. The smell is thoroughly nauseating. Flies buzz in the air while various dead bugs float on the viscous surface.

Durst History: A successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Religion)** or **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check** will reveal these items were being collected for a demon-summoning ritual.

Dobromir History: **Death House** summoned a **cambion** and minor fiends to stop a House cleansing ritual. The cambion used these materials (and **cultists**) to open a gate to the Abyss so that it could escape the House.

29. Shadowy Crossroads

For the Lead PC:

> You slowly approach a dark crossroad of intersecting tunnels. The shadows seem to deepen and the walls close in. You are startled by a blur of darkness that rushes by and you think you barely see a humanoid creature... or is it your own shadow? Your mind swims and your vitality seeps away in the darkness...

Undead Combat Encounter (Low/Moderate Difficulty):

Weaker or Average Parties: When one or more characters reach the midpoint of the four-way tunnel intersection, four **shadows** rise up out of the ground in the spaces marked X on the map and attack. The shadows hide and attack from behind the characters, along the walls nearby, fighting until destroyed.

Stronger Parties: For stronger parties you may consider alternatively using a **shadow demon**. If the party is very strong, you may consider slowly adding **shadow(s)** to the encounter.

30. Stairs Down

> An extensive set of stone steps descend down into abyssal darkness. You notice small footstep prints in the slick blood and mud along the side wall, heading down. The silence below is broken by a strange, mystical chant. The sound is ominous and menacing. Your gut is screaming at you to run and escape, but you know in your heart that something vile is about to happen below.

Footprints. The footprints are Ireena's. If Rose is with the party, she will prod them to investigate. The characters will arrive in Area 35 after descending this 20-foot-long staircase.

31. Angelic Tears

> This room is encircled with skeletons whose arms suspend from corroded manacles against the walls. They wear the meager, tattered robes of monks; wooden holy symbols of the Morninglord gracing their necks. A 15-foot-wide alcove in the southern wall holds an ancient stone altar where the sigil of the Morninglord has been scratched and marred. Near the altar, a marble stone statue looks upon the desecrated shrine morosely. A restful, serene peace fills you in this holy place.

Founding History: This room's purpose and décor goes back to the House's founding. Initially this was a secret holy shrine to the **Morninglord** that was desecrated. The monks were starved for their "crimes of piety", the altar marred, but the statue was untouched.

The Statue:

> The statue is of an angel that has a basin at her feet. The angel looks remarkably like Rose. The design makes it appear that she is weeping into the basin, but the water in the basin is actually dripping from the ceiling above the alcove.



Holy Water of Dawn. The water in the basin is divinely blessed with increased potency (3d6 radiant damage). There is enough holy water in the basin to fill six flasks. A successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check** will discern that there is also a ***Ring of Fire Resistance*** at the bottom of the basin.

Concealed Door. Characters searching the room find a concealed door in the middle of the east wall with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. The door pulls open to reveal a stone staircase that climbs 10 feet to a landing (Area 32).

A few small footprints (Ireena's) lead into the room from the doorway, but the trail ends soon thereafter. They are heading to the crossroads intersection (Area 29).

32. Hidden Trapdoor

Behind the rotted remains of a door, stairs ascend to a landing. On the landing is a ladder that rises up six feet to a trapdoor that is bolted shut from this side.

The character may choose to leave the trapdoor alone, or they may open it:

Sliding the bolt out from its locked position you open the trapdoor and are startled to find yourself in the corner of the tea room, on the first floor of the house. You never noticed this trapdoor when you were in this room before.

The trapdoor opens on to Area 3, above.

Development:

Once the trapdoor has been found and opened from this side, it remains accessible to the characters as a way into and out of the dungeon level.

33. Abyssal Antechamber

This antechamber is sparsely furnished. A tarnished chandelier overhangs an oak table with pieces of shattered pottery atop it. A pair of high-backed wooden chairs and two unlit standing candelabras complete the dismal setting. Strangely, this room has the distinct smell of sulfur and brimstone.

The table once had a clay jug and two clay flagons on top. The sulfur smell grows stronger, coming from Area 34.

34. Abyssal Bedchamber

This 15-foot-square bedchamber is grimy. Large sections of the earthen walls have fallen into the room from the east and north. A shabby straw-filled mattress sits on an oak bedframe while a footlocker rests against an empty wardrobe. The smell of sulfur and brimstone is overpowering here, making you gag involuntarily.

Something stirs within the hole in the north wall. At first all you see are a malevolent pair of crimson eyes. Next, a massive black hound steps out to face you, smoky tendrils of fire rippling from its snarling maw.

Hell Hound Combat Encounter (Moderate Difficulty):

Weaker or Average Parties: The danger of this fight lies in the fire damage that a **hell hound** produces, so instead of a recharge, the creature is modified to use the ability once per day.

Stronger Parties: In this scenario there is room to add maybe one (coming from the east wall) for a strong party or two (another lying on the bed) more **hell hounds** for a very strong party.

Keep in mind that two or more hounds will benefit from the advantage created by the **pack tactics** (the hound has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the hound's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated) ability. You may want to play-test this before deciding on the number of hell hounds required to moderately challenge your party.

Treasure. Characters searching the footlocker find a folded ***Cloak of Protection***, a ***+1 Magical Weapon*** that the party needs (DM's discretion), a small wooden coffer (unlocked) containing four ***Potions of Healing*** (2d4+2), a chain shirt, a mess kit, a flask of alchemist's fire, a bullseye lantern, a set of thieves' tools, and a spellbook with a yellow leather cover containing the following wizard spells:

1st level: ***Disguise Self***, ***Identify***, ***Mage Armor***, ***Magic Missile***, ***Protection from Evil and Good***

2nd level: ***Darkvision***, ***Hold Person***, ***Invisibility***, ***Magic Weapon***

These items were taken from adventurers who were killed by the Durst **Cult of Strahd**.

35. Chamber of Suffering Souls

Alcoves exhibiting gruesome "trophies" encircle this rectangular chamber—severed human extremities disgustingly displayed. A man clothed in a black, hooded robe is slumped over in a chair facing the room in the southeast corner, his hands shackled behind him and his ankles manacled to the chair. In the silence between drips of water you can hear him mumble, over and over, like a faint chant, "*He is the Ancient. He is the Land.*" Then he breathes his last breath, like a long sigh, before expiring.

Dobromir History: In this House memory, the priests of the **Cult of Strahd** were imprisoned, systematically tortured, and sacrificed by a summoned **cambion**. It opened an Abyssal Gate in Area 38 so that it could escape the **House**.

The southernmost tunnel slopes down at a 20-degree angle into gloomy water and ends at a corroded portcullis (Area 37). If the PC(s) spent one hour in the first basement level, the clock will chime **11 p.m.** throughout the House.



36. Chamber of Imprisoned Souls

Continuing down the corridor, a prison stretches westward before you in a depressing despondency. You hear the rattling of shackles and the coarse breathing of tortured prisoners. The stone walls and floors are discolored a bright-red from recent grisly events.

Two of the original thirteen **cultists** (CE, human males) remain half-dead here, shackled as prisoners to the back walls of the cells. They are forever trapped in the House so it is useless for the party to free them (rusty iron **manacles** that can be picked with **thieves' tools** and a successful **DC 15 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check**).

This is just another delaying tactic the House is using and astute characters may understand this with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana)** or **(Religion) check**. Otherwise, the party will discover this when the two "grateful" cultists attack them after being freed.

Secret Door. Characters searching the area find a secret door in the south wall with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. It opens to reveal Area 38 beyond.

Treasure. Hanging on the back wall of the cell marked X on the map is a recently dead cultist clothed in a tattered black robe. If a character searches the body, they will find a **gold ring** (worth 25 gp) on one of his fingers.



37. Raised Portcullis

The short staircase descends into 2-feet-deep, murky water as it levels out into a larger pool in the room beyond. A raised, corroded-iron portcullis flashes sharp teeth at you from above this entry to the room beyond. Around the corner, you spot the edge of a wooden wheel embedded into the wall that operates the portcullis mechanism.

This tunnel can be blocked by the iron portcullis that is raised or lowered by turning a wooden wheel embedded in the east wall of Area 38. The wheel is beyond the reach of someone east of the portcullis.

If found on the wrong side of the lowered portcullis it can be forcibly lifted with a successful **DC 20 Strength (Athletics) check**. Using a crowbar as a lever will grant an **advantage**.

38. Dark Heart of Death House

The room you've entered is shrouded in an eerie darkness; the air thick with anticipation. The black water, like a forgotten memory, clings to the floor, its surface broken only by the occasional ripple. The stone ledges, worn and ancient, seem to defy the dampness, rising against the encroaching murk.

In the center of the room, more stairs ascend to form an octangular platform that is also above the water-level. Long chains attached to shackles dangle from the spacious 16-foot-high ceiling, grimly above a stone altar mounted on the platform. The altar is carved with repulsive bas-reliefs of ghouls ripping apart corpses, and is stained with ancient blood.

Two black-robed figures each hold the wrist of an obviously distraught teenaged young woman. They are attempting to place her into the shackles while she fights back viciously. The figures are chanting, "*One must die! One must die! One must die!*" over and over as they struggle with their newfound prey.

A ruined gap in the west wall reveals a macabre scene—a throne of bones atop a pile of debris, half-submerged in murky water. The room seems to pulse with an otherworldly energy, and a hooded woman seated upon the throne is its dark heart.

Her eyes, crimson like smoldering coals, lock onto yours. Hatred radiates from her gaze, and you feel it like a physical weight. She is no ordinary specter; her malevolence is palpable, a force that threatens to consume you. The bundle strapped to her chest draws your attention—a grotesque secret hidden in plain sight. *A stillborn baby's skeletal remains are visible in the bundle strapped to her chest!*

The water is 2 feet deep. The ledges and central dais are 5 feet high (3 feet higher than the water's surface), and the chamber's ceiling is 16 feet high (11 feet above the dais and ledges). The chains dangling from the ceiling are 8 feet long with **manacles** attached.



Roleplaying Opportunity: The young woman is Ireena Strazni (LG female human noble) who was recently caught peering into the chamber. Ireena is a striking young woman with auburn hair. She was born and raised in Vallaki with her brother, Izek. One morning recently, their father and their uncle took them fishing on Lake Zarovich. On the way back to town, a dire wolf attacked Izek and bit off his right arm. Their father carried Izek back to town while their uncle distracted the beast. Ireena ran and hid in the Svalich Woods and was lost in the Mists until she found herself here. She is completely shocked and traumatized, barely able to remember her first name. She is dirty, tattered, bruised, and half-starved to death.

The characters are Ireena's best hope for protection, so she is willing to accompany them to escape this nightmarish House. Although she appears mild, she has a strong will, and she aids the party as best she can in saving herself.



Durst Cult Combat Encounter (High/Very High Difficulty):

Weaker or Average Parties: One of the two hooded cult figures is a **ghoul**. The other is plainly **Gustav Durst**, a **ghast**, recognizable from his formal clothing seen in the family portrait (Area 6). The seated woman is **Elisabeth Durst**, another **ghast**.

Stronger Parties: Optionally, for stronger parties, the cultist and **Gustav Durst** are **ghasts** and **Elisabeth Durst** may optionally be a **ghast gravecaller**. She will be familiar from her features seen in the family portrait (Area 6).

If the fight gets too ugly for the party, you can choose to have Rose intervene for a ghostly battle witnessed by the party while they rescue Ireena and flee the **House**.

If the battle is going poorly for Elisabeth Durst (the party has freed Ireena and are coming for Elisabeth), the **House** will summon a **graveyard revenant** from the bone and debris pile to attack the party. It is adapted to fulfill the **House**'s wishes.

> You watch in horror as an abomination stirs, a ghastly amalgamation of innumerable undead souls—an abhorrent mass of rot, malevolence, and unyielding will—emerges from the heap of debris. It advances with sickening intent: limbs intertwined in grotesque symphony, mouths agape in an eternal scream, a united force of insidious terror. Your breath catches as you stand, frozen, before the throne. The monstrosity shifts with a wet, slithering motion, its limbs writhing in disjointed harmony, dragging itself closer.
>
> Will you confront the woman, seeking answers? Or will you retreat, leaving the manor's secrets buried in darkness? Choose wisely, for the rotting titan looms closer, and midnight swiftly approaches...

Mental Stress Save. Watching a huge mound of undead bodies rise up in front of them is enough to create a **mandatory DC 15 Wisdom Mental Stress Saving Throw**. On a failed save, a character becomes **frightened** and must use their action (**Dash**) and movement each round to flee from the source of the fear. Ireena will run, a signal for the characters to flee also. Rose (if present) will follow Ireena to protect her. This fear will last for ten minutes. These effects can be suppressed with the ***Calm Emotions*** spell or removed by the ***Lesser Restoration*** spell.

The characters do not need to attack the graveyard revenant; in fact, the portcullis remains raised up, and Ireena runs—telltale signs that they **can** flee. Your players' first instinct will probably be to attack the monstrosity—a fight they will most likely lose. If they do fight, and if the graveyard revenant dies, the House will continue to harass and delay the characters as they try to escape.





The Great Escape

Run Away!

> The foundations of the House shake as a massive tremor strikes. Dust, debris, and boulders crash into the murky water, splashing you with a gruesome spray. You sprint from the foul ritual chamber, racing each other to escape, Ireena's eyes wide in terror. You sense that the very House is trying to kill you, to keep you eternally trapped here. The mists rise from the earthen dungeon floor, grasping... clawing... rending... at your feet. Howling wails of horror and torment echo behind you, filling you with a dark dread. One thought pounds in your head... Midnight... we must escape by MIDNIGHT!

Much debate has been stirred about the quickest route to escape Death House and what format (roleplay challenge, skill challenge, homebrewed house rules, etc.) for the escape is ***best*** for DMs and players to use. Simply said, it doesn't require all of that to escape Death House.

First, Rose has supernatural powers for what occurs in the escape. At the very least, the players can rest assured knowing that, even if their characters fail, Rose will ensure that Ireena will be rescued from the House.

Second, you must be aware of the time and keep the players aware of the time. The timing is what drives the story, builds dread, and frames the horror theme.

Lastly, a simplified, ***optional*** format is provided below. **You may always use your own favored method!**

Death House's Tactics (Optional)

The Mists of Ravenloft continue to surround Death House until the character(s) exit through the front gate. When the characters return upstairs, they must roll for initiative (keep track of initiative as the characters make their way through the house: it may make a difference at the end depending on the time) as they discover several architectural changes:

- ***Haunted Zone.*** During the Great Escape only, any creature that casts a spell within Death House must first succeed on a **DC 17 Constitution Saving Throw**. If the saving throw fails, the spell fails and is wasted.
- All the windows and the doors to the Balconies (Areas 12C and 15C) are gone and bricked up; the bricked-up windows, doors, and the outer walls are impervious to the party's weapon attacks and damage-dealing spells.
- **If you have time:** The armor (the number is at your discretion depending on APL strength, maximum of 4) in the Upper Hall (Area 6) will become **animated armor**, move to, and defend the Main Hall (Area 2).
- The red carpet in the Grand Foyer (Area 1B) is animated by the House as an **animated rug of smothering**. It acts like a tongue, tripping up characters, entangling them, or pushing them into the Portico teeth as they try to flee.
- The doors in the Portico (Area 1A) are replaced by slashing teeth-like blades. A character must succeed on a **DC 13 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check** to pass through this teeth-trapped doorway unscathed. A character who spends 1 minute studying the teeth can try to take advantage of a momentary gap in their repeating movements and make a **DC 13 Intelligence check** instead. Failing either check, a character takes 10 (2d10) slashing damage but manages to pass through the doorway. Any creature pushed through a doorway must succeed on a **DC 13 Dexterity Saving Throw** or take the damage. The teeth can't be disarmed (but you can remind players of their heroic inspiration).
- Every room that contains a fireplace, an oven, or a stove is set on fire and has thick, black smoke. The room is heavily obscured, and any creature that starts its turn in the smoke must succeed on a **DC 10 Constitution** or **Wisdom** (player's choice) **Saving Throw** or be coughing and confused for 1 minute.
- The interior walls become rotted and brittle. Each 5-foot-section has AC 5 and 5 hit points, and can also be destroyed with a successful **DC 10 Strength** (Athletics) **check**. Each 5-foot section of wall that's destroyed causes a swarm of rats to pour out and attack. The swarm won't leave the house.

DM's Option: Rose's Tactics

Rose will attempt to guide and protect Ireena (and the party), while also thwarting the House's tactics and continuing to cause its complete collapse for the rest of *this* resurrected **Death House** form. All of these tactics are available as a **DM's Option**, depending on your timing:

- If the party did not find the concealed door in Area 31 and trap door to Area 3, you may have Rose guide them to find this quick exit from the House.
- Rose has the ability to **incapacitate** the **animated armor** within a 10-foot-radius of her presence as if it is in the area of an ***Antimagic Field***.
- While in her presence, a character gains an **advantage** to the checks and saving throws associated with the teeth blades (or you can remind them to use their **inspiration**).
- Any character that is **confused** by the smoke can be guided by the hand. Rose, Thorn, Wilhelm, and/or Brigetta will help them from that room, granting them enough stability of mind to be led out calmly.
- Rose fears and hates rats. They are worse than a graveyard revenant. The characters are on their own dealing with them.
- If the party does not have the spell ***Dispel Evil and Good***, Rose may be gifted by the **Morninglord** to cast it on the party's behalf, otherwise the House can revive in 24 hours. Casting the spell will cause the House to go into a stasis for 13 years of Barovian time before reviving.

'Tis Midnight: The Doomed

You hear the creaky hinges of the front gate beginning to close, attempting to seal you inside! You feel an adrenaline surge push you beyond your normal physical limits, a last-ditch effort to escape this nightmarish House! Your breathing comes in ragged gasps, your lungs ache, your muscles fatigue with the strain. Each step echoes with a chime of the House clock. Then you hear the last chime of the House clock strike midnight...

Shocked, you watch in terror as the gates slam shut, just as you are about to reach them. Running into the closed iron bars, you press your face against them and futilely try to bend them, press them open, squeeze through... there just was not enough time. One more minute... one more second...

Strangely, you see Rose and Thorn outside in the clearing, more solid and real to you than before, standing beside a winded, fading Ireena. At least Ireena made it out safely, you muse.

Then the Mists come for you, devouring the physical world outside, obscuring everything. Turning back from the gate you sense that the House itself is alive, a foul monstrosity, feeding on your tortured soul and your horrific death.

Then you fully realize that you are *dead*, just another anguished ghost in this twisted manor. You know that this Death House is your prison of torment... forever.

THE END.

If the character is doomed, you may present the player with a black rose as a memento. If the character survives, the player may be presented with a red rose. This is optional, of course, just a final gothic touch.

Afore Midnight: The Survivors

Rose and Thorn materialize at the gates suddenly, struggling to hold the corroded metal open for you with ghostly hands. Rose shouts, "Hurry! We can't hold it much longer!"

You see Brigetta and Wilhelm appear as well, wrestling open the gates against the supernatural strength of the House. "Hurry!" Brigetta cries in anguish.

To the rusted iron gates you sprint, the howling wails of the dead clawing at your backs. You feel an adrenaline surge push you beyond your normal physical limits, a last-ditch effort to escape this nightmarish House! Your breathing comes in ragged gasps, your lungs ache, your muscles fatigue with the strain. Each step echoes with a chime of the House clock. Each chime resounds like thunder in your ears.

You dive and stumble past the struggling benevolent spirits, out of the House, into the cool night air of the clearing in the woods, gasping to catch your breath. You hear the final chime of midnight come from the clock within the House. There is a sudden **SLAM**! The gates are shut. You watch Rose fall exhausted to her knees in the stone portico, Thorn clutching his doll at her side.

"Farewell..." she says to you with a relieved smile, "...and thank you."

As Rose, Thorn, Wilhelm, and Brigetta dissipate slowly into the ethereal haze, you watch the House quake as if in a death throe, collapsing in on itself unexpectedly. A cloud of dust and debris shoots up into the sky as large cracks form in the earth around you. Shocked, you scramble quickly away, fearful that the House may get you yet.

At a safer distance, you look at the terrified Ireena catching her breath, and you are grateful to be out of that House with her. The full realization of what you all just endured strikes you like a hammer blow. You are not entirely sure if your psyche will ever recover from the horror of it all. You distinctly hear your mental sanity crack... and then abruptly SHATTER like broken glass.

MILESTONE DEVELOPMENT

Escaping Death House. Once the character(s) have escaped with Ireena, each character receives:

- A **heroic inspiration**. If a character gains a Heroic Inspiration but already have it, it's lost unless they give it to a player character who lacks it.
- **One experience level**. Let the players update their sheets while you update your records.
- Allow the characters to recover hit points, change spells, etc., as if they have been through a **long rest**.
- Optionally, you may have the characters make a **DC 13 Wisdom Saving Throw**. If they fail, the character may gain a **mental stress effect** at your discretion.

Next Steps

Roleplaying Opportunity: Kolyan Indirovich (LG male human noble), the Burgomaster of the Village of Barovia, has been in the Svalich Woods nearby participating in an annual hunt for wild game. He will have his son, Ismark (LG male human warrior veteran) with him. They heard the sound of Death House's collapse and came to investigate.

When they encounter the party and Ireena, they will offer their aid and a return to their hunting camp, a mere quarter-mile away in the woods. There is little doubt to their good character and sincere offer, and Ireena is hungry and in shock, so this is a truly benevolent and hospitable act that the characters are in a bad position to turn down. They will share a hot meal of venison and vegetables, along with some Barovian wine. From there they can offer wagon transportation through the woods to the Village of Barovia, a mile away to the southeast... and on to their next adventure. You can use this encounter with the burgomaster and Ismark to foreshadow or set out adventure hooks for future adventures in Barovia.

As you may have guessed, Ireena will soon be adopted by the Burgomaster and become Ireena Kolyana. She is a possible incarnation of Tatyana, the subject of Strahd's obsession, and thus a *Curse of Strahd* story nexus NPC. If the characters continue their adventures in Barovia, they will see her again... *and* will have a shared history of survival within, and escape from, Death House.

Excalibur Penn
2023 - 2025



Appendix A: DM Tips

The Dungeon Master

The Dungeon Master has a special role in D&D games.

The DM is a **storyteller**. The DM presents the challenges and encounters that the characters must overcome. The DM is the players' interface to the D&D world, who reads (and sometimes also writes) the adventure and describes what happens in response to the characters' actions.

The DM is a **referee**. When it's not clear what ought to happen next, the DM decides how to apply the rules and keep the story going.

The DM is a **roleplayer**. The DM plays the monsters in the adventure, choosing their actions and rolling dice for their attacks. The DM also plays all the other people the characters meet, including helpful ones.

A Good DM

The most important part of being a good DM is facilitating the fun of everyone at the table. Keep these tips in mind to help things go smoothly:

Embrace the shared story. D&D is about telling a story as a group, so let the players contribute to the outcome through the words and deeds of their characters. If some players are reluctant to speak up, ask them what their characters are doing.

It's not a competition. The DM isn't competing against the player characters. Your job is to referee the rules, run monsters, and keep the story moving.

Be fair and flexible. Treat your players in a fair, impartial manner. The rules help you do this, but you can make your own rulings to ensure everyone is having fun.

Modify the adventure to suit your tastes. The adventure can be changed by you at any time. You can alter any encounter to make it more interesting and fun for your players.

Keep a notepad handy. Use it to track details such as the characters' and monsters' initiative order.

Sharing Information. As Dungeon Master, one of your most important tasks is figuring out how much to tell the players and when. All the information the players need to make choices comes from you. Within the rules of the game and the limits of the characters' knowledge and senses, tell players everything they need to know.

You don't have to reveal every aspect of a situation or hazard in one go. Boxed text typically describes everything the characters see, hear, or smell at first glance. As characters search rooms, make Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Investigation) checks, open drawers and chests, and generally examine things more closely, give players more details about what their characters find.

Rolling With the Unexpected

D&D Players love to do things that their DMs can't possibly anticipate, and at the same time, Dungeon Masters are encouraged to customize the content of adventures, mixing and matching bits here and there to make the final story as-played, their own.

This adventure focuses on roleplaying and encourages heroic antics, so if the players do something to surprise you that might "break" an encounter... roll with it!

Be ready to adjust details on the fly and you should endeavor to have this adventure play out like a combination of a horror movie where the protagonist is just a normal person, a mystery or action movie where the odds are stacked against them, and just a touch of cinematic heroic excitement.

Adjusting this Adventure

This adventure provides the following suggestions in making adjustments for smaller or larger groups, characters of higher or lower levels, and characters that are more powerful than the adventure is optimized for. You're not bound to these adjustments; they're here for your convenience and optimization.

To figure out whether you should consider adjusting the adventure, add up the total levels of all the characters and divide the total by the number of characters (rounding .5 or greater up; .4 or less down). This is the group's Average Party Level (APL). To approximate the party strength for the adventure, consult the following table:

Determining Party Strength Table

Party Composition	Average Party Level	Strength
2-3 characters	APL less than	Very weak
2-3 characters	APL equivalent	Weak
2-3 characters	APL greater than	Average
4-5 characters	APL less than	Weak
4-5 characters	APL equivalent	Average
4-5 characters	APL greater than	Strong
6-7 characters	APL less than	Average
6-7 characters	APL equivalent	Strong
6-7 characters	APL greater than	Very strong

Scaling the Adventure

Sometimes as an adventure unfolds, a group of characters may prove to be too weak or too strong for the combat encounters. It may be due to a variety of reasons. Possibly it is by virtue of their APL, because of their tactics, magical items, or some other factor. Consider using the following options, if needed:

Weaker party (Very weak or weak) adjustments:

- Create a skill challenge or roleplay challenge rather than a combat encounter.
- Decrease damage by an incremental lower scaled die (e.g., a trap that deals 2d6 acid damage now deals 1d6 acid damage (very weak) or 2d4 acid damage (weak)).
- Decrease the DC of skills/saves by increments of -2.
- Adapt the creature to a similar creature of lower CR.
- Reduce the number of creatures.
- Decrease creature hit points by one half.
- Use flawed tactics or creature failures/weaknesses.
- A helpful Sidekick/Survivor/NPC comes to their aid.

Stronger party (Strong or very strong) adjustments:

- Increase damage by an incremental higher scaled die.
- Increase the DC of skills/saves by increments of +2.
- Adapt the creature to a similar creature of higher CR.
- Add or create another wave of the lowest CR creature.
- Increase creature hit points to maximum.
- Use improved tactics, or have creatures call for help.

Appendix B: Additional Maps





